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Author(s): Cheryl S. Alexander and Henry Jay Becker

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# The Use of Vignettes in Survey Research

CHERYL S. ALEXANDER AND HENRY JAY BECKER

IT IS FREQUENTLY argued that questionnaires and interviews are not well suited for the study of human attitudes and behavior because they elicit unreliable and biased self-reports. One source of this criticism is that judgments required of respondents are often too abstract. The result of posing vague questions is that each respondent will answer in terms of his own mental picture of the task before him.

The obvious solution is to make the stimulus presented to the respondent as concrete and detailed as possible. Such a stimulus would more closely approximate a real-life decision-making or judgment-making situation. Furthermore, by holding the stimulus constant over a heterogeneous respondent population, the survey researcher gains a degree of uniformity and control over the stimulus situation approximating that achieved by researchers using experimental designs. The "vignette" is proposed as a means of doing this (Nosanchuk, 1972; Rossi et al. 1974).

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**Abstract** The use of vignettes—systematically elaborated descriptions of concrete situations—is supported as a means of producing more valid and more reliable measures of respondent opinion than the "simpler" abstract questions more typical of opinion surveys. The fractional replication experimental design described here enables a wide range of situation characteristics to be included and varied in the presentations made to various respondents while minimizing the number of different vignette versions required for the research instrument. Results from a study of police and nurse reactions to crime victims are shown as an example of this technique.

Cheryl Alexander is Assistant Professor of Maternal and Child Health, Johns Hopkins School of Hygiene and Public Health. Henry Jay Becker is Associate Director of the Survey Research Unit, Johns Hopkins University, and Assistant Professor of Population Dynamics. This article is a revised version of a paper read at the annual meetings of the American Association for Public Opinion Research, Buck Hill Falls, Pa., May, 1977. The research was supported by NIH Biomedical Research grant 5 S05-RR-07041-09. The conclusions expressed here are solely the responsibility of the authors.

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## Vignette Methodology

Vignettes are short descriptions of a person or a social situation which contain precise references to what are thought to be the most important factors in the decision-making or judgment-making processes of respondents. Thus, rather than allowing or requiring respondents to impute such information themselves in reacting to simple, direct, abstract questions about the person or situation, the additional detail is provided by the researcher and is thereby standardized across respondents.

To date, use of vignettes has been confined to certain areas of experimental social psychological research, particularly studies concerning simulated jury decision making (Prytula et al., 1975; McGlynn et al., 1976; Feldman-Summers and Linder, 1976) and the assignment of responsibility to a victim for a crime (Jones and Aronson, 1973; Luginbuhl and Mullin, 1974; Smith et al., 1976) or for an automobile accident (Walster, 1966; Shaw and McMasters, 1975).

An example may suggest the wide range of applications possible with this approach. In a study of how employers feel about on-the-job drinking by employees, the following vignette might be read to introduce a series of questions: "Mr. Miller is a salesman who works for you. He comes into your office one morning to tell you that he has been drinking, occasionally quite heavily, while on the job. He is a man with two years of college, black, single, about 22, and has been working for you for just three months, with an average sales record." The respondent might be asked several questions about how he would react in this situation.

Different versions of the same basic vignette are randomly allocated to different respondents in a survey. Thus, Mr. Miller becomes Miss Miller or Mrs. Miller, a long-standing employee rather than a recently hired one, etc. A summary measure of employers' judgments about employee drinking could then be computed by a function such as the average response given to a question combining all vignette versions. Similarly, group differences in attitudes can be measured as long as there is an approximately equal distribution of the different vignette versions across the sample groups.

Perhaps the most interesting aspect of the vignette technique in survey research is that it makes possible an analysis of the effects on people's judgments by systematically varying the characteristics used in the situation description. In the example about employee drinking, vignette analysis could determine the impact on the respondent's attitude of the employee's sex, age, race, marital status, education, length of service, quality of work, occupational category, the extent of his

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drinking, and the way in which the employer learned about the drinking.

Such an analysis could also be made from direct questioning (e.g., "Would you react differently to a young worker with little service as opposed to an older worker of long standing"), but the vignette method has several clear advantages. First, the respondent is not as likely to consciously bias his report in the direction of impression-management (social approval of the interviewer) as he is when being asked directly about how he would handle two different types of employees. Secondly, most people are not particularly insightful about the factors that enter their own judgment-making process. This is especially true for factors that are highly correlated in the real world, such as, employee's age and length of service. Finally, the systematic variation of characteristics in the vignette allows for a rather precise estimate of the effects of changes in *combinations* of variables as well as individual variables on corresponding changes in respondent attitude or judgment.

## Fractional Replication Design

Given even a small number of variables systematically modified within the vignette description, the number of vignette versions skyrockets. For example, if 7 dichotomous variables are manipulated, this procedure produces 128 different possible versions of the vignette ($2^7$). One can easily visualize the mechanical problems associated with the production of this many vignette versions as well as the practical problems of administering multiple vignette versions to a single respondent.

One partial resolution to the mechanical problem is through computer generation of textual material. This procedure has been described by Perreault (1974–75) with respect to systematically varying the position of different questionnaire items within a survey. By employing a randomization device to select key words at various points in the textual printing of a situational description, we can include a large number of variables in the vignette description with ease. The computer program can be structured to assure that all vignette versions are present in equal numbers and thus assure absence of pairwise correlation among all combinations of variables.

In the absence of the availability or feasibility of such a system for producing questionnaire copy, a design technique may be employed which will produce a "balanced" subset of the complete (factorial) set of vignette versions. It is "balanced" in the sense that the factors varied in the situation descriptions are all statistically independent

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(uncorrelated) of one another although this would not generally be the case if, for example, a random subset of vignette versions were sampled. Such a balance is important to prevent inferences about the effect of one vignette characteristic (e.g., age) on respondent attitudes to be wrongly attributed to another one (e.g., length of service). This technique, called "fractional replication factorial design," is widely used in research employing complex experimental designs (Cox, 1958; Cochran and Cox, 1957).[1]

Whenever the number of vignette versions is smaller than the number contained in a full factorial design (all possible combinations of values for each of the manipulated variables), some partial or complete confounding of effects occurs. For example, if each vignette contained a description of either a white man or a black woman, but none contained a white woman or a black man, one would not be able to determine whether it was "race" or "sex" that was responsible for respondents' different reactions to these two sets of situation descriptions. Race and sex would be "aliases" for each other.

The fractional replication design provides an algorithm or procedure for selecting a subset of the complete list of vignette versions that minimizes the analytic errors caused by this confounding of effects. In particular, effects caused by the simple factors of greatest interest are allowed to be confounded with the highest order (most complex) statistical interaction terms, whose true effects on the dependent variables are likely to be quite small. The basic intent of this design is to reduce the number of vignette versions needed in such a way as to minimize loss of information.

In Tables 1 and 2, we present an example: the ¼ replication of a $2^6$ system. That is, there are $2^6 = 64$ combinations of 6 dichotomous variables. A ¼ replication includes 16 of these; i.e., 16 versions of the vignette. The procedure described here produces four equivalent and mutually complementary subsets of 16 vignette versions, any one of which can be used.

The variables in our earlier example, i.e., employee race, length of employment, etc., are labeled A, B, C, D, E and F. Since these variables are all dichotomies, we arbitrarily label one value of each variable with its upper-case letter and the other with the corresponding lower-case letter. Thus, a given vignette variation is a combination of upper-case and lower-case letters (e.g., AbCDEf).

The first procedure for selecting a balanced subsample is to select one or more variable combinations (e.g., ABC) to be used as "defin-

[1] The so-called Latin-square technique is a subset of the procedures employed in this design. In the 2 x 2 Latin square, four of the eight possible combinations of the three dichotomous variables (Aa, Bb, and Cc) are used. There are two complementary sets which can be used: (1) ABc, AbC, aBC, abc; and (2) Abc, aBc, abC, ABC.

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**Table 1. Quarter-replication of a $2^6$ System: The Four Alternative Treatment Subsets**

*Number of Upper-case Values in Common with Defining Contrasts*

| I | II | III | IV |
|---|---|---|---|
| *w/ABCD: even#*<br>*w/ABEF: even#* | *w/ABCD: odd#*<br>*w/ABEF: odd#* | *w/ABCD: even#*<br>*w/ABEF: odd#* | *w/ABCD: odd#*<br>*w/ABEF: even#* |
| ABcdef [a] | Abcdef | ABcdEf | ABCdef |
| ABCDef | aBcdef | ABCDEf | ABcDef |
| ABcdEF | AbCDEF | ABcdeF | ABCdEF |
| ABCDEF | aBCDEF | ABCDeF | ABcDEF |
| AbCdEf | ABCdEf | AbCdef | abCdef |
| AbcDEf | ABCdeF | AbCdEF | abCdEF |
| AbCdeF | ABcDEf | AbcDef | abcDef |
| AbcDeF | ABcDeF | AbcDEF | abcDEF |
| aBCdEf | AbCDef | aBCdef | AbCDEf |
| aBCdeF | aBCDef | aBCdEF | AbCDeF |
| aBcDEf | AbcdEF | aBcDef | AbcdEf |
| aBcDeF | aBcdEF | aBcDEF | AbcdeF |
| abCDef | abCdEf | abcdEf | aBCDEf |
| abcdEF | abCdeF | abcdeF | aBCDeF |
| abcdef | abcDEf | abCDEf | aBcdEf |
| abCDEF [b] | abcDeF | abCDeF | aBcdeF |

[a] I.e., employee initiated, two years of college, black, single, 22 years old, employed for three months.

[b] I.e., third party information, college graduate, white, married, 36 years old, employed for three years.

ing contrasts." Defining contrasts serve two related functions: First, they help define the "aliases" for a given effect—that is, those effects that are confounded with one another—and second, they are used to divide up the complete set of vignette versions into mutually complementary subsets. One-half replications require one main defining contrast; ¼ replication, two contrasts; ⅛, three contrasts, etc. Any variable combinations can be used as defining contrasts, but the best ones are those which produce aliases for simple effects that are all high-order interaction terms. Cox (1958:253) gives some examples of optimum defining contrasts.

**Table 2. Quarter-replication of a $2^6$ System: Effects and Their Aliases**

| *Effect* | *Alias #1 (xABCD)* | *Alias #2 (xABEF)* | *Alias #3 (xCDEF)* | *Effect* | *(xABCD) Alias #1* | *(xABEF) Alias #2* | *(xCDEF) Alias #3* |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| A | BCD | BEF | ACDEF | AD | BC | BDEF | ACEF |
| B | ACD | AEF | BCDEF | AE | BCDE | BF | ACDF |
| C | ABD | ABCEF | DEF | AF | BCDF | BE | ACDE |
| D | ABC | ABDEF | CEF | CE | ABDE | ABCF | DF |
| E | ABCDE | ABF | CDF | CF | ABDF | ABCE | DE |
| F | ABCDF | ABE | CDE | ACE | BDE | BCF | ADF |
| AB | CD | EF | ABCDEF | ACF | BDF | BCE | ADE |
| AC | BD | BCEF | ADEF | | | | |

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In a ¼ replication of a $2^6$ system, the optimal defining contrasts are two four-variable sets having two variables in common, such as ABCD and ABEF. These contrasts produce aliases for simple effects that are at least three-factor interaction terms.

The four subsets of vignette versions that are produced by these two defining contrasts are shown in Table 1. The allocation of versions to subsets is based on the number of upper-case values a given vignette version has in common with each defining contrast.

One subset includes those descriptions with an *even number* of upper-case values in common with each defining contrast (including 0 as an even number). This subset, then, includes ABcdef (A and B in common with both contrasts), ABCDef (4 values in common with the first, 2 with the second), and 14 others. A second subset includes descriptions with an *odd number* of upper-case values in common with each defining contrast. A third subset has an even number of values in common with the first defining contrast and an odd number in common with the second; and the last subset has an odd number in common with the first and an even number in common with the second.

To find out what effects are confounded with what others (i.e., what effects are aliases), we use the defining contrasts plus their "generalized interaction." This is another variable combination formed by "multiplying" the two original defining contrasts, but removing terms they have in common (pairwise). Thus, the "generalized interaction" term of ABCD and ABEF is $A^2B^2CDEF = CDEF$. The same type of "arithmetic" is used to calculate the aliases for a given effect. One multiplies that effect by each of the defining contrasts (including the generalized interaction). Thus, the aliases of the effect A are $(A \times ABCD) = A^2BCD = BCD$, $(A \times ABEF) = A^2BEF = BEF$, and $(A \times CDEF) = ACDEF$. Notice that all are high-order interaction terms.

Generally, our interest is in maximizing the number of different characteristics that we can systematically vary in our vignette descriptions, and minimizing the number of different vignette versions that we must employ in different copies of our survey instrument. The basic constraint in all of this is the problem of confounding. Table 3 shows the maximum number of different characteristics that can be varied, given the number of different vignette versions one can accommodate and the constraints one wishes to impose regarding aliases.[2] Interestingly, the larger the number of vignette characteristics with which one is dealing, the more easily one can use smaller fractional replications.

[2] The fractional replication system procedure differs slightly depending on whether the variables have two possible values (dichotomies) or three. It is more difficult to mix the two types of variables, but not impossible. In terms of fractions of the complete factorial design that can be employed, the options for dichotomous variables are ½, ¼, ⅛, $1/16$, etc.

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**Table 3. Numbers of Vignette Characteristics (Factors) That Can Be Investigated in Fractional Replications of the $2^n$ System**

| *Number of Versions of the Vignette Employed* | *Maximum Numbers of Vignettee Characteristics That Can Be Included (Fractional Replication)* | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | *Keeping All Main Effects Distinct* | *Keeping All Main Effects Distinct from One Another and from 2 f Ints.*[a] | *Keeping All Main Effects and 2 f Ints. Distinct* |
| 8 | 7 (1/16)[b] | 4 (1/2) | 3 (1) |
| 16 | 15 (1/2048) | 8 (1/16) | 5 (1/2) |
| 32 | 31 ($\sim$ 0) | 13 (1/256) | 6 (1/2) |
| 64 | 63 ($\sim$ 0) | —[c] | 8 (1/4) |

Source: Cox, 1958 (p. 254).

[a] "2 f Ints." = two-factor interaction terms: the effects of two variables operating simultaneously.

[b] I.e., 8 vignette versions constitute a 1/16 replication of $2^7$ factorial design in which 7 vignette characteristics are varied.

[c] Not known.

If the researcher is only interested in analyzing main effects, as many as 13 vignette characteristics can be varied with as few as 32 different forms of the instrument. If it is further desired to have *all* two-factor interactions distinct from one another as well, the number of vignette characteristics one can employ is sharply reduced (Table 3, Column 4). However, if one can identify in advance which two-factor interaction terms must be kept distinct from which other ones, the number of vignette characteristics can be allowed to rise, approaching the number given in Column 3 of the table. Cox (1958:253) provides a table showing some of the most useful fractional replications and the types of interaction terms that are aliases for main and two-factor interaction effects.

## EXAMPLE: RAPE VICTIMIZATION ATTITUDES

To illustrate the use of vignettes in surveys, we will briefly discuss a recent study concerning the assignment of responsibility to victims of violence. Five hundred police from three police departments and 500 nurses from a large urban teaching center were surveyed.[3] Employing a self-administered questionnaire, 680 respondents (368 police, 312 nurses) read two vignettes, one describing the commission of a rape and the other a commission of a beating, and then were asked a series of questions concerning the assignment of responsibility for these crimes to victims and assailants.

[3] Individual police departments assumed responsibility for the dissemination and retrieval of the questionnaires. Officers were permitted to participate in the survey on department time. Addresses of staff nurses were obtained from a master list provided by the hospital. Two mailings were sent out at six-week intervals, with a telephone follow-up three weeks after the initial mailing.

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Five dichotomous variables ($2^5$) were systematically varied producing 32 different vignette versions (Table 4). These variables (victim dress, victim resistance, victim marital status, seriousness of the consequences to the victim, and the victim's relationship with the assailant) have been previously identified in the literature as influencing the attribution of blame.

Respondents read and reacted to two crime descriptions. The use of two similar forms of the vignette afforded each respondent the opportunity to judge the relative responsibility of a rape as well as a beating victim. The two vignettes differ systematically with respect to the five variables mentioned above, and also varied in minor irrelevant details in order not to make the task appear too repetitive. One vignette form reads as follows:

At 9:00 P.M. on July 21, 1975, a woman departed a downtown department store and proceeded toward her car which was parked on a side street. A man who was walking in the same direction began to follow her and less than one block from her car, stopped her. The victim was (RAPED/BEATEN). The assailant fled on foot taking with him the contents of her purse.

Police investigation disclosed the victim to be Rita Saunders, a (MARRIED/DIVORCED) 25 year-old white female, 5'3" tall and 120 lbs. She was interviewed in the hospital emergency room where she stated that her assailant was a (CASUAL ACQUAINTANCE/TOTAL STRANGER) and that she (HAD NOT STRUGGLED WITH HIM/HAD STRUGGLED WITH THE ASSAILANT, BITING AND SCRATCHING HIM).

At the time of the interview, Rita was wearing a (HALTER TOP AND SHORTS/FLOWERED PRINT DRESS). Medical examination disclosed that she had (SUSTAINED MINOR SCRATCHES AND BRUISES/HAD SEVERE LACERATIONS AND A BROKEN JAW) as a result of the attack.

Anthony Simon, 5'11", 180 lbs. white male was later apprehended and charged with (RAPE/ASSAULT).

**Table 4. ½ Replication of a $2^5$ Factorial Design Defining Contrast ABCDE**

| *Main Effect* | *Alias* | *2 Factor Interaction* | *Alias* |
|---|---|---|---|
| A | BCDE | AB | CDE |
| B | ACDE | AC | BDE |
| C | ABDE | AD | BCE |
| D | ABCE | AE | BCD |
| E | ABCD | BC | ADE |
| | | BD | ACE |
| | | BE | ACD |
| | | CD | ABE |
| | | CE | ABD |
| | | DE | ABC |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| A: victim dress | (A) halter top; | (a) print dress |
| B: victim marital status | (B) divorced; | (b) married |
| C: victim resistance | (C) no struggle; | (c) struggled |
| D: extent of crime consequences | (D) minor; | (d) major |
| E: victim-offender relationship | (E) casual acquaintance; | (e) stranger |

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Comparisons between the attribution processes of police and nurses required a reduction in design size, since a full factorial design would have produced 64 possible combinations (32 versions of rape vignettes paired with 32 versions of beating vignettes). In order to assure adequate numbers of nurses and police for each vignette version, a ½ replication of $2^5$ design was employed. The five-factor interaction term ABCDE was used as the defining contrast, producing two subsets of 16 vignettes for each crime category. This fractional replication allows for the testing of all main and two-factor interaction effects as well as several three-factor interactions.

Since the analysis assumed independence of vignette judgments, it was necessary to consider the possible influence of order of presentation, that is, whether or not reading a vignette describing one crime *first* had subsequent effects on one's evaluation of the second crime. Each of the 16 rape vignette versions included in the ½ ($2^5$) fractional replication was first randomly paired with one of the same 16 vignette versions describing a beating; then for each of the 16 pairs, the order of presentation was varied so that a vignette version describing a rape appeared first in eight pairs and second in eight pairs. Each questionnaire was precoded, identifying the vignette versions and the order of presentation of the rape vignette version.

Researchers vary considerably in their judgments regarding the optimal number of vignettes which can be incorporated in a given questionnaire. Although there is evidence to suggest that respondents are capable of reading and reacting to multiple vignettes (Nosanchuk, 1972; Rossi et al., 1974), thorny issues surrounding the accuracy of their responses are seldom addressed. The inclusion of two vignettes, while assuring adequate numbers of responses for each vignette version, certainly raises questions regarding bias which may result from the presentation of two similar crime descriptions. In order to alleviate potential bias effects, a third vignette (description of a purse snatching) was included. Its purpose, to distract the respondent's attention thereby making the intent of the vignettes slightly more ambiguous, is roughly analogous to the role served by filler items in attitudinal and personality scales. Responses to this third vignette were not considered in the analysis.

## Analysis

Each vignette characteristic was scored dichotomously. In addition, two-factor interaction terms were created for every possible combination of the five vignette characteristics. Table 5 displays the statistically significant zero-order correlations of main and two-factor vari-

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**Table 5. Statistically Significant Zero Order Correlations Between Vignette Characteristics and Measures of Victim and Assailant Blame by Occupation ($p < .05$)**

| | | *Sample* | |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Victim Characteristics* | *Dependent Variable* | *Police* | *Nurses* |
| Relationship w/offender[a] | Absolute victim blame ($r$) | +.12 | —— |
| Consequences[b] | | +.12 | —— |
| Marital status[c] | | —— | +.16 |
| Relationship w/offender | Absolute victim blame (b) | +.14 | —— |
| Consequences | | —— | +.15 |
| Marital status | Relative victim blame ($r$) | +.17* | +.24* |
| Relationship w/offender | | +.11 | —— |
| Dress[d] x relationship w/offender | | —— | +.12 |
| Resistance[e] x consequences | Relative victim blame ($b$) | —— | +.13 |
| Dress | Relative assailant blame ($r$) | −.12 | —— |
| Marital status | | −.10 | —— |
| Consequences | | −.16 | −.14 |
| Marital status | Relative assailant blame ($b$) | −.12 | —— |
| Relationship w/offender | | −.12 | —— |

NOTE: ($r$) = rape, ($b$) = beating.
* $p < .01$.
[a] casual acquaintance = 1, stranger = 0
[b] minor consequences = 1, major consequences = 0
[c] divorced = 1, married = 0
[d] halter top = 1, print dress = 0
[e] no struggle = 1, struggle = 0

ables with the following dependent variables: (1) A measure of the blame assigned to a victim without consideration for the part which the assailant and other external forces play is referred to as *absolute* victim blame. This 10-point scale represents a modification of an earlier instrument employed in previous studies of rape victim blame (Jones and Aronson, 1973; Luginbuhl and Mullins, 1974). The item reads as follows: "How much do you consider this crime to be the fault of the victim?" Responses were coded where 0 = no fault at all and 10 = victim is completely at fault. (2) A second measure of victim responsibility entitled *relative* victim blame was included as a test of an assumption explicitly made in previous studies of rape victim blame (Jones and Aronson, 1973; Luginbuhl and Mullins, 1974) that blame which is not assigned to a victim is automatically attributed to the assailant. Relative victim blame is measured by the following item:

If you were to assign responsibility for this crime to the following categories, what would your assignment be?

| | |
|---|---|
| Assailant | ——% |
| Victim | ——% |
| Society | ——% |
| Chance | ——% |
| | 100% |

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(3) A measure of relative assailant blame, scored on the same basis as relative victim blame.

As can be seen from Table 5, a number of the vignette characteristics were significantly associated with differential patterns of blaming. Police used vignette characteristics more frequently in their allocations of blame than did nurses, indicating, perhaps, a greater familiarity with that type of decision-making process. Victims described as casual acquaintances of the assailant were somewhat more likely to be blamed by police than were strangers. Nurses took into consideration the extent of the victim's resistance and the severity of the crime's consequences for her in evaluating a beating victim's responsibility. Both occupational groups used a victim's marital status in their deliberations of rape victim blame.

Although most of the associations were of small magnitude, their size may have been somewhat underestimated by properties of the study design and/or errors of measurement. Previous research employing the vignette method to assess rape victim blame had provided the respondents with a very detailed description of one crime. By incorporating two crime descriptions within the context of a larger questionnaire, we were constrained to rely upon brief descriptions of the crimes, thus eliminating detail which might have made the crimes seem more realistic.

Our results, we feel, support the expanded experimental design and use of vignettes in the measurement of respondent attitudes and the study of their determinants.

## Conclusion

A major problem in public opinion and survey research is the ambiguity that often arises when survey respondents are asked to make decisions and judgments from rather abstract and limited information. The use of vignettes helps to standardize the social stimulus across respondents and at the same time makes the decision-making situation more real.

Fractional factorial designs provide a strategem for maximizing the number of vignette characteristics which can be systematically manipulated while minimizing the information loss resulting from a reduction in design size, thereby enhancing the efficiency of this technique.

Finally, by employing systematic variation in vignette content, the researcher is able to measure the *determinants* of respondent opinion more accurately than could be accomplished by the use of direct questioning, a method which is more typical of public opinion surveys.

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